

NF AUDIO TOOLS

NF – STRESSOR

REDLINE / 1% THD



Owner's Manual

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OVERVIEW

NF – Stressor is a faithful, from-scratch emulation of a classic opto/FET rack compressor, built as a tall, narrow vertical strip inspired by outboard hardware. It covers the full signature behaviour of the original design: a fixed internal threshold driven by the INPUT knob, a true discrete OPTO mode at the ends of the ATTACK/RELEASE travel, a hard-knee “NUKE” ratio stage, and independent character (distortion) switches.

Everything on the panel mirrors real hardware conventions — there is no dedicated THRESHOLD knob; instead, INPUT drives your signal harder or softer against a fixed internal reference, exactly like the classic units this plugin is inspired by.

Tip: because there's no threshold control, gain reduction is driven entirely by how hard you push INPUT. Start low and raise it until the GR meter starts moving.

Formats

- macOS: VST3 and Audio Unit (AU), Intel and Apple Silicon.
- Windows: VST3, 64-bit.

INSTALLATION

macOS

Run the NF – Stressor installer package and follow the prompts. It installs both VST3 and AU into the standard per-user plug-in folders:

- **VST3:** ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/
- **AU:** ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/

Windows

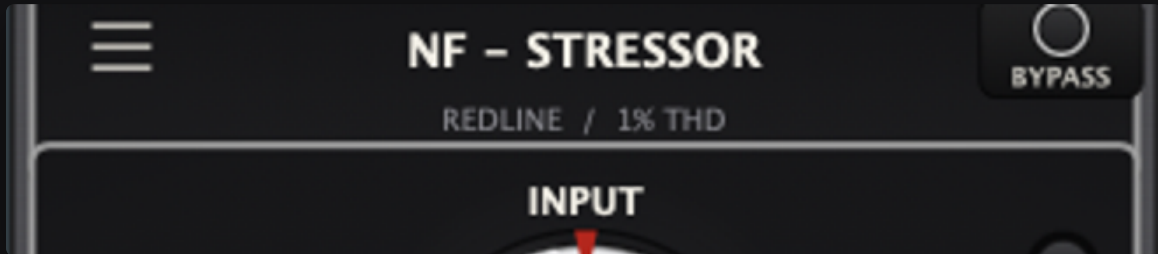
Run NF-Stressor-Setup.exe and follow the wizard. It installs the VST3 into the standard system-wide folder:

- **VST3:** C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\

After installing, rescan plug-ins in your DAW if it doesn't pick up NF – Stressor automatically.

INTERFACE TOUR

The panel is a single vertical strip, read top to bottom: brand plate and BYPASS at the top, the four main knobs with the gain-reduction ladder meter beside them, the RATIO row, the DETECTOR/AUDIO character switches, and finally MIX with the NUKE button.



The hamburger icon (top-left) opens the preset menu. BYPASS (top-right) disengages processing entirely — its LED blinks while active as a reminder.



INPUT, ATTACK, RELEASE and OUTPUT, each with a rotating numbered dial (0–10) and a fixed red index mark at the top. The ladder of LEDs on the right shows live gain reduction in dB.

MAIN CONTROLS

INPUT

Drives the signal into the compressor's fixed internal threshold. There is no separate threshold control — turning INPUT up pushes the signal harder against that reference, increasing gain reduction.

ATTACK

Sets how quickly the compressor reacts to a transient, from a fast FET-like response at low settings to a much slower response as you approach the top of the range.

RELEASE

Sets how quickly gain reduction lets go after the signal drops, from a fast release at the bottom of the range to a slow one near the top.

OPTO mode: turning ATTACK all the way up (past 9) or RELEASE all the way down (below 1) blends the fixed FET timing into a real program-dependent response — attack softens on bigger transients, and release remembers recent gain reduction and takes longer to let go the harder it's been hit. A small LED beside each knob lights up when you're in that zone, and a white reference mark on the chassis shows exactly where the end-stop is.



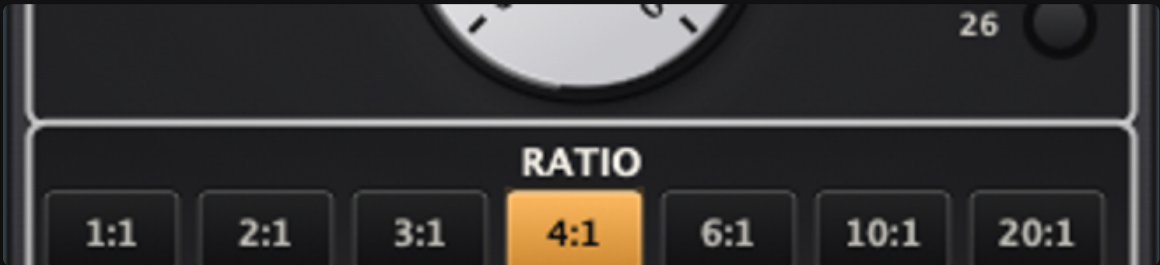
Both OPTO LEDs lit: ATTACK pushed past 9, RELEASE pulled below 1.

OUTPUT

Trims the final output level after compression, character shaping and mix.

RATIO

Selects the compression ratio. 1:1 through 6:1 behave as classic soft-knee compression. 10:1 and 20:1 engage an extra “redline” stage: a harder knee and a touch more drive into the character stage, matching the tagline lighting up amber.



1:1	2:1	3:1	4:1	6:1	10:1	20:1
Soft-knee compression					Redline / harder knee	

NUKE: a dedicated button beside MIX, independent of RATIO. Engaging it layers a true brick-wall limiter on top of whatever ratio is dialled in — an effectively infinite ratio, a razor-thin knee, a near-instant catch regardless of the ATTACK knob, and extra harmonic bite. Use it when you need a hard ceiling, not just more compression.



NUKE engaged (blue) beside a driven MIX knob.

DETECTOR & AUDIO



DETECTOR

HP

Engages a fixed high-pass filter in the sidechain, so low end doesn't dominate the detector's decisions — useful on bass-heavy sources.

LINK

Links the detector across both channels of a stereo signal so gain reduction tracks together, avoiding image shift on stereo material.

AUDIO

DIST 2 / DIST 3

Two independent character switches shaping the tone of the compressed signal: DIST 2 alone gives an FET-ish, asymmetric edge; DIST 3 alone gives a smoother, more opto-ish drive; engaging both together gives a coloured, more aggressive “British” character.



DIST 2 and DIST 3 both engaged — the coloured “British” character.

MIX, BYPASS & METERING

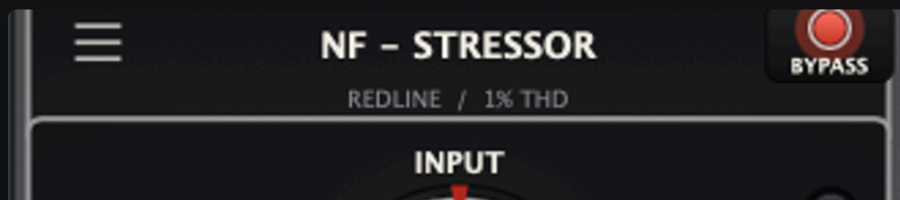


MIX

Blends dry and compressed (wet) signal, for parallel compression — keep the punch of the uncompressed signal while still catching peaks.

BYPASS

Disengages all processing. The LED and the word BYPASS blink together while engaged, so it's never ambiguous that the plugin is doing nothing.



BYPASS engaged — the LED and label blink together while active.

GAIN REDUCTION LADDER

A vertical LED ladder marked in dB (1 through 26) shows live gain reduction: green for light reduction, amber from 6 dB, red from 12 dB up — matching the NUKE/redline territory.



The ladder mid-reduction: green, amber and red zones all lit.

PRESETS

Click the hamburger icon in the top-left corner to open the preset menu:



The preset menu, with a saved preset ready to recall.

- **Default** — resets every control to its factory value.
- **Save Preset...** — writes the current settings to a preset file you name.
- **Load Preset...** — opens a preset file from anywhere on disk.

Any preset saved into the default presets folder also appears directly in this menu for one-click recall.

USAGE TIPS

- For vocals: moderate RATIO (3:1–4:1), ATTACK around the middle, RELEASE toward OPTO for natural, program-dependent release.
- For drum bus glue: LINK on, HP on to keep kick/bass from pumping the detector, RATIO 4:1–6:1.
- For aggressive drum room/parallel duty: push INPUT hard, RATIO 20:1, MIX under 50% to blend in the squashed signal under the dry track.
- Reach for NUKE only when you need a hard ceiling on top of your ratio — it's a limiter stage, not a subtler compression option.

CREDITS & VERSION

NF – Stressor is developed by NF Audio Tools. This manual and the plugin describe version v0.1.

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